

THE 12-PROMPT SHEET

12 laws that make AI images look cinematic, each with a prompt you can copy.

How to use it

1. Pick an image: your own photo or one from an AI tool.
2. For GENERATE prompts, replace [brackets] with your idea and paste into any image generator.
3. For EDIT prompts, upload your photo to an editor that accepts images (Gemini or ChatGPT) and paste the prompt.
4. Apply the laws in order: exposure, then color, then grain last.

Good to know

AI editing is not a real color grade. If you post a result, label it AI-edited. Results vary by tool, so generate 2 or 3 versions and pick the closest to your original. If a tool changes the composition, add: do not redraw anything, only change color and contrast.

01 Prompt for flat light. Grade later.

A flat, low-contrast image has room to grade. Baked-in contrast does not.

GENERATE PROMPT

```
Cinematic wide shot of [your subject], soft overcast light, flat low-contrast look, muted colors, no harsh shadows, shot on ARRI Alexa, 35mm film, high detail
```

02 Name the lens.

The lens decides the depth, the compression and the whole mood.

GENERATE PROMPT

```
[your subject], shot on a 35mm lens, shallow depth of field, f/1.8, natural lens flare, cinematic framing
```

VARIATIONS

```
Swap 35mm for 85mm (portraits) or anamorphic (wide, epic scenes).
```

03 Fix exposure before color.

Set blacks, whites and mids first. Color looks wrong on a bad base.

EDIT PROMPT (upload your photo first)

```
Edit this photo. Correct the exposure only: recover bright highlights, open the darkest shadows slightly, set natural black and white points. Do not change the colors or the composition.
```

04 Teal shadows, warm highlights.

The classic split. Cool the dark areas, warm the bright ones.

EDIT PROMPT (upload your photo first)

```
Edit this photo with a cinematic color grade. Add teal tones to the shadows and to the sea or background, keep the highlights warm orange. Keep the exact composition unchanged. Do not add or remove any objects.
```

05 Protect the skin tones.

Heavy teal on a face looks sick. Keep skin natural and warm.

EDIT PROMPT (upload your photo first)

```
Edit this photo. Apply teal tones to the shadows and background only. Keep all skin tones natural and warm. Do not tint faces blue or green. Keep the composition unchanged.
```

06 Contrast sets the mood.

Deep blacks feel dramatic. Lifted blacks feel soft.

EDIT PROMPT: DRAMATIC

```
Edit this photo. Make it moodier: deepen the blacks, lower the exposure slightly, strong contrast. Keep the composition unchanged.
```

EDIT PROMPT: SOFT

```
Edit this photo. Make it softer: lifted blacks, gentle contrast, light and airy. Keep the composition unchanged.
```

07 Pull saturation. Keep one accent.

Muted colors look expensive. Let a single color pop.

EDIT PROMPT (upload your photo first)

```
Edit this photo. Reduce the overall saturation by about 30 percent. Keep only the [orange sky] vivid as the single accent color. Keep the composition unchanged.
```

08 Halation on highlights only.

A soft glow on bright edges, like real film. Never on the whole frame.

EDIT PROMPT (upload your photo first)

```
Edit this photo. Add a subtle red-orange halation glow around the brightest highlights only, like film. Do not blur the rest of the image. Keep the composition unchanged.
```

09 Grain goes last.

Add it after the grade. Subtle, never heavy.

EDIT PROMPT (upload your photo first)

```
Edit this photo. Add fine, subtle 35mm film grain evenly across the image. Do not blur or soften any details. Keep the composition and colors unchanged.
```

10 Match shots before you stylize.

Make every image consistent first. Then add the look.

EDIT PROMPT (upload two images)

```
Match the color grade of the first image to the second image: same white balance, contrast, saturation and tones. Keep the composition of the first image unchanged.
```

11 Check it on a phone.

Your audience watches on a phone. Judge it there, at thumbnail size.

CRITIQUE PROMPT (upload your image)

```
Critique this image for viewing on a small phone screen. Is the subject clear at thumbnail size? Is the contrast strong enough? Suggest three specific changes to color, contrast and framing.
```

12 Save every winning look.

Turn a grade you like into a recipe you can reuse on any image.

RECIPE PROMPT (upload the graded image)

```
Describe the color grade of this image as a reusable recipe: shadow color,
highlight color, contrast, saturation, grain, vignette. Then write one short
prompt I can paste to apply the same look to other images.
```

BONUS

The master grade prompt

The one used for the before/after in the carousel. Works best on landscapes and city scenes.

EDIT PROMPT (upload your photo first)

```
Edit this photo with a cinematic color grade. Keep the exact composition
unchanged: same objects, no additions or removals. Deepen the shadows with
teal tones, keep the sky warm orange with richer saturation near the horizon,
add strong but natural contrast with deep blacks, a soft glow around the
bright horizon, subtle film grain and a light vignette. Photorealistic, 35mm
anamorphic film look. High resolution.
```

If the result is too strong, add: reduce the saturation by 20 percent, keep it natural.

Made your first cinematic image?

Tag @ai.dailytimes and send it to me. I share the best ones.

Daily cinematic AI, web motion and UI/UX.

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